The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Iran and the White House both denied that the US navy had escorted an oil tanker through the **Strait of Hormuz**, contradicting an earlier claim made on X by America's energy secretary, Chris Wright. The post was quickly removed, but still helped push oil prices lower. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, briefly dropped below $80 a barrel, continuing a slide that began with Donald Trump's mixed messages about the war in Iran on Monday.

Meanwhile Mr Trump said that America had "completely destroyed" ten inactive **mine-laying vessels** in Iran, and warned the country against placing mines in Hormuz. He said he had "no reports of them doing so" although some media outlets have reported that Iran is planting mines there. Earlier Pete Hegseth, America's defence chief, threatened that Tuesday would be the "most intense day of strikes inside Iran".

Oracle reported quarterly revenues of $17.2bn—a 22% rise on the same period a year ago—beating analysts' expectations. The software giant has been investing heavily in cloud-computing infrastructure to compete with Amazon and Microsoft. Oracle raised its revenue forecast for next year to $90bn, citing strong

demand for its cloud services, which are used to train AI; its share price rose by 9% in after-hours trading.

Ursula von der Leyen suggested that Germany had been wrong to shut down its nuclear reactors—a phase-out it completed in 2023. The president of the European Commission said that it had been a "strategic mistake" for the bloc to "turn its back on a reliable, affordable source of low-emissions power". The EU's executive arm is promoting the roll-out of small modular reactors to diversify Europe's electricity supplies.

Bill Ackman filed to list a new closed-end fund, Pershing Square USA, on the New York Stock Exchange. As part of a dual listing, investors will also receive shares in Mr Ackman's parent hedge-fund management company. The IPO aims to raise $5-10bn. The listing revives Mr Ackman's long-stated ambition to build a "modern-day Berkshire Hathaway", emulating the financial empire of Warren Buffett, after earlier attempts fell flat.

Police in **Canada** began investigating a shooting outside the **American consulate** in Toronto as a "national security incident". Two people reportedly shot at the building before fleeing; no injuries were reported. The attack comes days after a series of shootings at synagogues in Toronto, although it is unclear if the incidents are related. Mark Carney, Canada's prime minister, called the shooting an "attempt at intimidation".

Meta said it would acquire **Moltbook**, a social network for AI agents that launched in January and quickly went viral. It did not disclose the price. As part of the deal Meta will hire Moltbook's two co-founders to work at its "superintelligence labs", the technology giant's AI unit for which it has spent hundreds of millions of dollars poaching researchers from rivals.

Figure of the day: 85%, the proportion of self-described MAGA Republicans who support America's attacks on Iran. Read the full

story.

Photograph: Getty Images

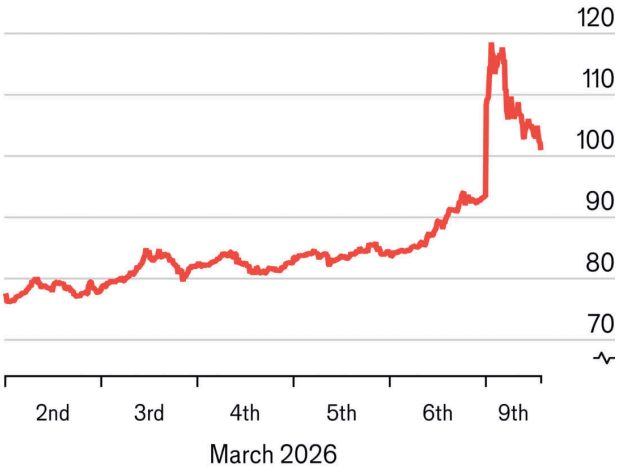
Saudi Aramco’s temporary advantage

Aramco released its full-year results on Tuesday, which revealed that profits at Saudi Arabia’s state-owned oil giant had fallen by 12% to $105bn. But investors were most interested in what has happened since February 28th when America and Israel began attacking Iran.

The firm’s share price has soared in the face of a severe oil shock, but Amin Nasser, Aramco’s boss, warned that the war could have “catastrophic consequences”. His firm already felt some pain. An Iranian drone strike shut down its biggest Saudi Arabian refinery; the company has reduced its output. But the world’s largest oil producer is better equipped to cope with the near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz than its competitors, and has begun rerouting shipments via the Red Sea. Meanwhile state energy companies in Bahrain, Kuwait and Qatar have triggered *force majeure* clauses, releasing them from liability for failure to meet existing contracts. For now, Aramco’s sheer scale is a buffer.

Slippery slope

Brent crude oil price, $ per barrel



Source: LSEG Workspace

Photograph: IMAGO

Germany seeks closer trade ties with America

German trade figures ended on a high note in 2025. Those year-end gains did not carry over into 2026. Exports were down by 2.3% compared with December, and imports slumped by 5.9%, according to the latest trade figures published by Destatis, the German statistics agency.

Last year China overtook America as Germany's biggest trading partner (a position it briefly lost to America in 2024). Bilateral trade between the countries amounted to $285bn, with a record deficit of $101bn for Germany. Uncertainty over erratic tariff policies caused exports to America to fall to €146.2bn, a 9.4% drop from the previous year. Germany still maintained a trade surplus with America of €51.9bn in 2025, but this was down from €69.6bn in 2024. German policymakers are eager to diversify away from China. They want deeper ties with America—even if America has other ideas.

Photograph: AP

Javier Milei showcases a transformed Argentina

On Tuesday Javier Milei, the president of Argentina, will speak at a glitzy event in New York as part of “Argentina week”, intended to drum up investment. He will probably boast about overhauling the country’s economy: inflation is down, growth is up and his government has passed stacks of legislation since 2023. That, Mr Milei is sure to point out, has created new opportunities to make big bucks in Argentina, from mining to data centres. Some new deals may even be announced.

Yet headwinds remain. There are still some capital controls in place, making it difficult to get money out. Meanwhile the potential return to power of the populist Peronist opposition at some point is a worry for any long-term investor. Mixed signals from the administration don’t help. Mr Milei’s government wants new investments but, in a recent U-turn, said it would not borrow from global capital markets to finance itself. (Interest rates would be too high, it argues.) The big event—in the heart of Wall Street—might suggest otherwise.

Photograph: Netflix

“One Piece” sails back

Netflix released the second season of “One Piece”, its adaptation of a Japanese manga and anime series, on Tuesday. The first season—which follows a ragtag crew of pirates—was the streaming giant’s most-watched show in the second half of 2023. The protagonists’ grinning skull-and-crossbones flag became a symbol of courage in the face of corrupt power at Gen Z protests in Nepal, Madagascar and other countries last year. New episodes will be shown at cinemas in North America and Japan.

Such popularity is unusual. Western live-action anime adaptations typically do terribly: “Dragonball Evolution” was a box-office disaster in 2009; Netflix rapidly cancelled “Cowboy Bebop” after one season in 2021. “One Piece” has succeeded by staying faithful to its source material—Oda Eiichiro, the original creator, oversees the Netflix show too. And its diverse casting has been well received by viewers. For an industry eyeing anime’s vast fanbase, “One Piece” may have finally charted the right course.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily Quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which William Somerset Maugham novel features a cholera epidemic in China?

Monday: Which was the second and last Bond film to feature Timothy Dalton?

There is no greater misfortune in the world than the loss of reason.

Mikhail Bulgakov